

The 2 and 4 chant

The '2 and 4 chant' is a fun way to teach your students an important lesson in jazz - that you need to clap on beats 2 and 4 to make the music 'swing'. It also jokingly refers to the "jazz police" - jazz purists who look down popular music and the younger generation of jazz musicians that blend genres e.g. hip hop and jazz.

The chant has 2 versions to try with your students - start with the echo (call & response version) with teacher as leader and students repeating back and then move on to the straight through version.

Methodology

1. Start by establishing the body percussion stamp, clap groove / ostinato (ostinato means a repeating pattern) Stamp on beats 1 and 3 and clap on beats 2 and 4. Count out loud at first and then encourage your students to use their 'thinking' voice and count the beats in their head. This groove is commonly found in gospel music.
2. Start with the echo version of the chant – teacher as leader but once your students know the chant, ask for volunteers to lead.
3. Follow the instructions in the chant about how to clap your hands – up high, down low, to the side (to the left) here we go (to the right)
4. Once your students feel confident with the echo version you can try the straight through version.
5. Try saying the chant over the iRealPro backing track.

Extension activities

As a follow here are some activities with an associated playlist to help your students internalise the beat when they listen to a piece of music and start to improvise rhythmic patterns. Research suggests that starting with rhythmic improvisation before moving on to melodic improvisation works well as it removes the pressure of pitch selection, allowing your students to focus on groove, timing, and phrasing.

2 and 4 Playlist

1. Choose a track from this playlist
<https://open.spotify.com/playlist/7H3S0bvnwZl1Zxh4vGzbnm?si=3758a6bee4b243e7>
2. Establish the 2 and 4 body percussion ostinato with your students by stamping on beats 1 and 3 and clapping on beats 2 and 4.
3. Turn down the volume of the track - tell your students to continue the body percussion ostinato.
4. Turn the volume back up and see if your students have kept in time with the track.

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	
CLAPPING ON THE BEAT – Teacher as leader and students copy back (then encourage students to be the leader)								
X								REPEAT
	X							REPEAT
					X			REPEAT
2 BEAT PATTERNS – try clapping 2 beats together for your students to copy back								
	X	X						REPEAT
			X	X				REPEAT
						X	X	REPEAT
MIXED PATTERNS – as these are more complicated it is fine to cycle them around until everyone 'gets it'								
	X		X	X				REPEAT
		X			X	X		REPEAT
X						X	X	REPEAT
COPY ME – clap 4 beat patterns using crotchets and quavers for your students to copy back								
TEACHER CALL beats 1-4				STUDENT RESPONSE beats 5-8				
DON'T CLAP THIS ONE BACK! – vary your rhythm patterns but if you clap 'don't clap this one back' your students remain silent								
X	X	xx	x					
ANSWER ME – Teacher claps an Improvised 'Question' rhythm and students clap back an improvised 'Answer' rhythm								

TEACHER QUESTION				STUDENT ANSWER				
CLAP 4 / IMPROVISE 4	Everyone claps 4 beats			PUT A PATTERN IN THE SPACE	Take turns to improvise for 4 beats			
X	X	X	X	IMPROVISE	IMPROVISE	IMPROVISE	IMPROVISE	
BODY PERCUSSION PATTERNS – try the same games using body percussion patterns instead of clapping as an extension activity								